



All dripped-Out

Bang & Olufsen has released its Golden Collection of devices as part of its 95th anniversary. <https://dgit.in/dec20-57>



RHA TrueControl ANC

RHA's new earbuds comes with ANC, wireless charging and a brand-new Connect app. <https://dgit.in/dec20-58>

Shure AONIC 5

For fans of a neutral sonic signature

Amidst the flurry of wireless audio devices being released recently, the Shure AONIC 5 is a wired pair of in-ear headphones, part of Shure's AONIC series of IEMs (in-ear monitors), boasting audiophile-grade accuracy. Priced at ₹42,999, these earphones do cost a pretty penny. So, let's see if they manage to deliver the performance that one expects at this relatively exorbitant price point.

What's in the box

The Shure AONIC 5's box is brimming with accessories and equipment such as a quarter-inch adapter for stereo and pro gear, a circular protective hard case for the earphones, and a nifty ear-wax cleaning tool for the earphones. You also get an assortment of ear tips including three pairs of Comply foam tips, four pairs of foam tips, three pairs of silicone ear-tips, one pair of yellow foam tips and finally, a pair of triple flange ear tips, all in different sizes.

Lastly, you also get three sets of swappable nozzles, each capable of slightly tweaking the sound profile of these earphones to Balanced, Warm or Bright sound signatures, and a tool that loosens and tightens the nozzles.

Build and design

The Shure AONIC 5's earpieces can also be detached from the cables in order to turn them into wireless with the Shure True Wireless Secure Fit Adapter. Internally, the earbuds house three balanced armature drivers with a frequency range spanning across 18Hz to 19kHz. The cables that extend from the earbuds are semi-rigid and semi-flexible, allowing them to take the requisite shape to sit snugly around your outer ear. The rest of the cable is pretty standard and sadly, isn't tangle-resistant. The right side cable



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houses an inline remote control, which feels a bit plasticky. However, the buttons on the remote are well-placed and tactile.

The assortment of memory foam tips and the relatively small form factor of earbuds lends to a comfortable and secure fit, even over extended periods of time. The looping-over-the-ear wearing design may be cumbersome in the beginning though. Overall, the AONIC 5 earphones are comfortable and extremely secure in the ear, which also boosts the passive isolation of these buds.

Performance

The unique trait of the Shure AONIC 5 earphones is the ability to change the sound signature by swapping between the three filter nozzles the company has provided, using the handy tool that they've packed in the box. The three nozzles come in different colours for easy identification – Translucent Gray for a Balanced sonic signature (installed by default), Translucent Black for a Warm sonic signature, and Translucent Clear for a Bright sonic signature. The nozzles offer a subtle adjustment in the sonic signature of the earphones. The Warm filter simply offers a 2.5dB decrease in the 1kHz to 8kHz frequency range while the Bright

filter offers a 2.5dB increase in the same frequency range. The lows and mids are untouched across all the filters, so don't expect thumpy bass response with the Warm filter, the Shure AONIC 5 just doesn't do thumpy bass.

Instead what you get are well-defined, controlled and articulate lows, and clear mids across all nozzles. In our opinion, the highs with the Bright filter are a bit too exaggerated, and a little more than an hour of listening with this filter can cause listening fatigue. On the other hand, the Warm filter, while pleasant to listen to, provides less prominent highs which takes away from the accuracy of the sound slightly. The Balanced filter was just right for us and had the most accurate, clean and natural sound.

One of the most striking things of the AONIC 5 is the great soundstage and the left/right stereo accuracy. The spatial imaging is top-notch with tracks such as *Shine On* by *Pink Floyd* having great accuracy when it comes to positioning instruments and vocals in the relatively wide stage.

Overall, these earphones will thrill audiophiles with their accurate sound. The transparency and clarity make these earphones ideal for checking sound mixes and for critical listening.

Verdict

The Shure AONIC 5 earphones are an excellent option for those who still prefer wired connectivity with a lossless signal. If you're looking for a pair of IEMs with a neutral response, these earphones are a great choice. However, for a more textured and dynamic sonic signature, you may have to look elsewhere.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

TYPE: In-ear | DRIVERS: Triple Balanced Armature | FREQUENCY RANGE: 18Hz-19.5kHz | IMPEDANCE: 36 ohms | NOISE ATTENUATION: Up to 37dB | SENSITIVITY: 117dB SPL @ 1mW | CABLE LENGTH: 50-inches | REPLACEABLE CABLE: Yes | PLUG TYPE: 1/8", 1/4" adapter | FEATURES: 3-button Remote, Built-in Mic, Swappable sound signature nozzles | COLOURS: Clear, Red, Black

CONTACT

SHURE | PHONE: N/A | EMAIL: india@shure.com | WEBSITE: <https://www.shure.com/en-ASIA>